NAME CHANGE PROGRAM, EQUALITY MICHIGAN

Program Founder & Director

Statewide Program serving 83 counties

SYSTEM GAP & NEED

1.

Having legal identification that reflects correct and accurate names and gender markers are not only affirming for essential for physical and psychological well-being, safety, and access to services. However, it is too often that for many LGBTQIA2S+ individuals seeking a legal name change, there are significant barriers from financial to procedural challenges. Through identifying this need, I was able to begin developing a Name Change Program, that housed under the ACE Department, that would aid transgender and non-binary individuals in having their legal name correspond with their preferred name. By addressing the cost and complexity of the name change process, we are able to to help ensure these individuals emotional and physical safety, reduce the risk of victimization, and empower them to fully partite in society.

PROGRAM DESIGN, LEADERSHIP, & EXECUTION

2.

From inception, the program was built to function as a statewide, replicable service model, rather than a one-time assistance effort. Program design decisions prioritized accessibility, sustainability, and legal accuracy.

- Developed standardized intake workflows, eligibility criteria, documentation processes, and compliance safeguards adaptable across Michigan's varied county court systems
- Led coordination with community partners and program staff to ensure procedural accuracy and reduce friction for participants
- Balanced demand, funding, and operational capacity by refining program details as participation increased
- Built trust with partners and institutions with limited prior experience serving transgender and nonbinary clients, strengthening cross-section collaboration
- Consistently addressed operational and funding barriers without compromising compliance or participant dignity

MEASURABLE OUTCOMES & LASTING IMPACT

3.

This Name Change Program has produced measurable, statewide outcomes while establishing a sustainable model for long-term success and institutional changes.

- 100+ individuals supported in completed legal name and gender marker changes across almost all counties and court jurisdictions
- Established a sustainable, replicable service model embedded within Equality Michigan's core programming
- Secured long-term funding to ensure ongoing service delivery and program expansion
- Positioned Equality Michigan as a trusted statewide resources for name change navigation and legal affirmation support

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RURAL PRIDE COLLECTIVE COALITION

Founding Director, Equality Michigan

Upper Peninsula of Michigan serving 5 counties

SYSTEM GAP & NEED

1.

LGBTQIA2S+ individuals in Michigan's Upper Peninsula experience compounded barriers driven by geographic isolation, limited service infrastructure, and a lack of coordinated, culturally responsive supports. Despite having higher rates of victimization and need in rural areas, the U.P. has historically lacked LGBTQ2S+-specific resources, reliable access to affirming healthcare and mental health services, and sustainable funding for community-based programming. Existing services were underutilized not due to lack of need, but because of information gaps, transportation challenges, economic constraints, and deep social isolation that left many individuals disconnected from both formal supports and broader LGBTQ2S+ networks

PROGRAM DESIGN, LEADERSHIP, & EXECUTION

2.

The Rural Pride Collective Coalition was established as a community-driven response to service gaps for LGBTQIA2S+ individuals in Michigan's Upper Peninsula. Building on over two years of engagement and assessment, it aims to align existing efforts and foster collaboration across healthcare, education, and community services. Guided by a community-based participatory framework, the coalition emphasizes the expertise of local residents, ensuring culturally responsive and geographically suitable strategies.

- Founded and provided strategic leadership for the RPCC, guiding its development from concept to formalized, multi-sector coalition
- Established the coalition's governance structure and strategic priorities, defining shared goals across community connectedness, healthcare access, economic support, education, and service utilization
- Designed and implemented a community-based participatory framework, centering U.P. resident expertise and experience to ensure locally ground strategies
- Aligned coalition efforts with Equality Michigan's statewide advocacy and service infrastructure, strengthening regional coordination while expanding organizational reach

MEASURABLE OUTCOMES & LASTING IMPACT

3.

- Established a multi-county coalition network with 15 formal partner organizations and ambassadors representing healthcare, education, tribal communities, youth organizations, and faith groups.
- Reached over 300 LGBTQIA2S+ individuals across multiple counties in the U.P. through events, referrals, and community-based programming
- Supported the launch of new, locally led initiatives, including the first large-scale Pride gathering in Escanaba, which catalyzed the formation of a new nonprofit Pride organization in Delta County.
- Built sustainable peer and intergenerational support models, including recurring support groups and book clubs drawing 30–40 participants monthly, with community members traveling over an hour to access affirming spaces.
- Formalized coalition governance and shared-leadership structures, positioning the Rural Pride Collective for long-term sustainability, expanded member leadership, and continued regional growth despite rural capacity constraints.

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